

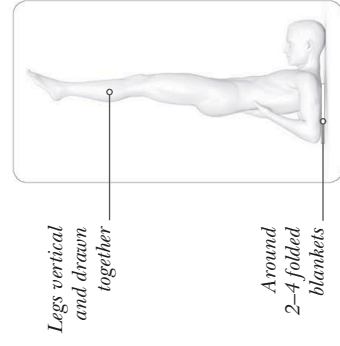
HALF SHOULDERSTAND

Ardha Sarvangasana

Shoulderstand is a **classic inversion**, often done at the end of an asana class to relax. It can help lower your blood pressure and activate the rest, digest, and rejuvenate part of your nervous system. The version shown here reduces pressure on the neck.

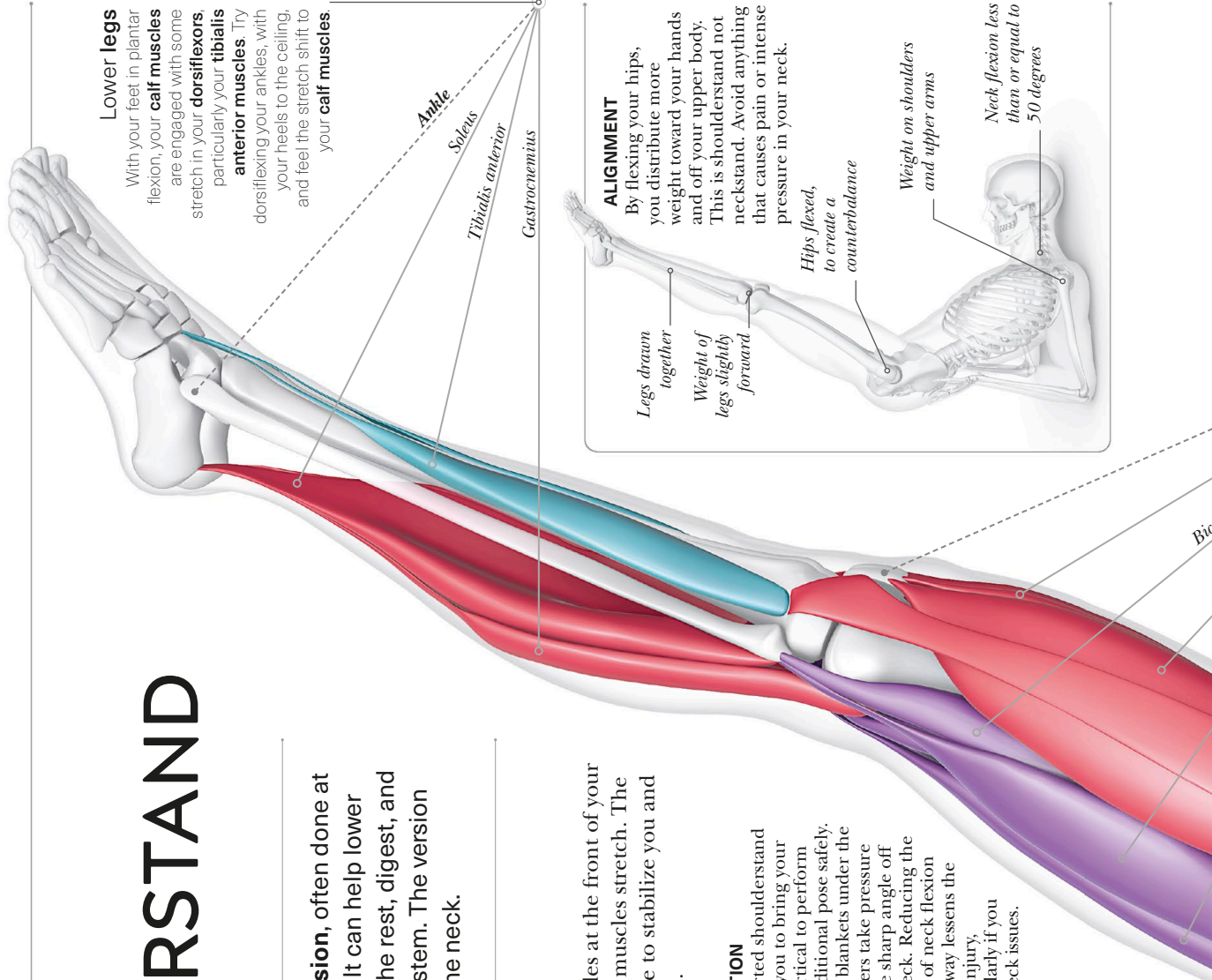
THE BIG PICTURE

This pose gently strengthens the muscles at the front of your neck, while your upper back and neck muscles stretch. The muscles of your core and thighs engage to stabilize you and hold your body in an inverted position.



VARIATION

Supported shoulderstand allows you to bring your legs vertical to perform the traditional pose safely. Folded blankets under the shoulders take pressure and the sharp angle off your neck. Reducing the degree of neck flexion in this way lessens the risk of injury, particularly if you have neck issues.



Lower legs

With your feet in plantar flexion, your **calf muscles** are engaged with some stretch in your **dorsiflexors**, particularly your **tibialis anterior** muscles. Try dorsiflexing your ankles, with your heels to the ceiling, and feel the stretch shift to your **calf muscles**.

Ankle

Soleus
Tibialis anterior

Gastrocnemius

ALIGNMENT

By flexing your hips, you distribute more weight toward your hands and off your upper body. This is shoulderstand not neckstand. Avoid anything that causes pain or intense pressure in your neck.

Hips flexed, to create a counterbalance

Weight on shoulders and upper arms

Neck flexion less than or equal to 50 degrees

Legs drawn together

Weight of legs slightly forward

Big